From AI opportunity to measurable impact.

A 90-day pilot proposal for fictional UK professional-services firm Northstar Advisory

The customer problem

Northstar has 500 employees and proposes a 100-user AI pilot. Teams spend time on repetitive administration, searching fragmented internal knowledge and drafting customer responses. Leadership needs evidence of value, adoption and responsible use before investing in a wider rollout.

Recommended opportunities

Start with customer response drafting and sales meeting preparation using Microsoft 365 Copilot, subject to prerequisites. Assess Copilot Studio for a tailored knowledge-support agent using approved sources and human escalation. Compare other tools or conventional automation where they better fit the workflow, environment or economics.

Illustrative first-year value

At 100 licensed users, 20 minutes saved per active user per day, 70% adoption, 220 working days and 50% realisation, the model estimates 2,567 effective hours and £89,833 in annual capacity value at £35 per hour. With £30,000 illustrative annual technology cost and £20,000 implementation and training cost, first-year net value is £39,833 and ROI is 80%.

What the numbers mean

Licence cost is an editable assumption of £25 per user per month, not Microsoft pricing. This is productivity capacity, not guaranteed cash savings. A real investment case requires measured baselines, validated licence and support costs, adoption evidence and a customer-specific assessment of how capacity will be used.

A clear path to a decision

Days 1–30 | Discover and prepare

Align sponsor, CIO, security and process owners; assess workflows and information permissions; select pilot and establish a baseline. Gate: a named owner, approved data access and agreed measures.

Days 31–60 | Pilot and validate

Train champions, test the selected workflows and monitor weekly active use, task time, answer quality and incidents. Gate: no unresolved critical risk and sufficient usage to evaluate.

Days 61–90 | Expand and optimise

Compare results with baseline, review the business case and agree an adoption and governance plan. Gate: the sponsor accepts the evidence, economics and control plan before expansion.

Commercial strategy

Qualify the pain, decision process, budget, sponsor and access to approved information. Engage a Microsoft partner where integration, security or change capability is needed. Position products against customer needs and assess alternatives without unsupported competitor claims.

Why this reflects my experience

I have built AI pilot programmes and ROI-led business cases at Aptem, worked with enterprise AI teams and data validation at Oxford Languages, and led workflow automation and user training at Meritto. My MSc research explored AI adoption. This simulation demonstrates my approach; it does not claim a live Microsoft Copilot deployment.

Recommended next step

Run a joint discovery workshop with the sponsor, CIO, security lead and customer operations owner. Agree a single workflow, baseline, pilot cohort, source permissions and decision criteria.